

700km

Flight range of Heli, UAE's autonomous cargo aircraft

250kg

Payload capacity of the hybrid autonomous cargo aircraft

The aircraft takes off vertically using battery-powered electric motors before going into horizontal flight.

UAE'S HYBRID CARGO AIRCRAFT UNDERTAKES MAIDEN FLIGHT

Heli, a hybrid autonomous cargo aircraft launched by Emirati company LOOD, made its maiden flight yesterday. The aircraft marks a national milestone and a global innovation in sustainable air transport, being the first civil aircraft to be fully designed, developed, and manufactured in the UAE by Emirati engineers, and dedicated to medium-range heavy cargo operations.

Ahmad Alotbi/Gulf News

A silent global crisis: Childhood hypertension doubles in 20 years

Childhood obesity, poor diet and sedentary lifestyles drive alarming trends

DUBAI
BY STEPHEN N. R.
Senior Associate Editor

Imagine being diagnosed with high blood pressure before even turning 13. Sounds unlikely, right? But global statistics paint a far more alarming picture. A sweeping new analysis published in *The Lancet Child & Adolescent Health* has found that hypertension among children and adolescents has nearly doubled between 2000 and 2020, transforming what was once an adult-only concern into a growing childhood crisis. According to the study, the proportion of under-19s liv-

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Over 114 million children and adolescents now live with high BP.
- Another 8.2% fall into the pre-hypertensive range.
- Rates spike sharply around early adolescence, especially at age 14.
- Boys have slightly higher rates than girls, but the gap is narrowing.
- Childhood obesity, poor diet, inactivity and screens are major drivers.
- 'Masked hypertension' — normal at clinic, high at home — is widespread and dangerous.
- India is facing a parallel crisis with 1 in 2 tested showing abnormal blood sugar.
- Diabetes, hypertension are hitting younger populations much earlier.

ing with high blood pressure rose from around 3.2 per cent in 2000 to over 6.2 per cent in 2020 — affecting an estimated 114 million children worldwide. Even more troubling, an additional 8.2 per cent fall into the "pre-hypertension" category, putting them at the threshold of risk. The surge comes against the

backdrop of rising childhood obesity, declining physical activity, ultraprocessed diets, and mounting stress levels among young people. Researchers evaluated 96 studies across 21 countries, and found that blood pressure levels spike sharply during early adolescence, peaking around age 14.



ENTERTAINMENT
On Glen Powell's bingo card: Scaling the Burj Khalifa 'Running Man' star takes action to the next level | P15

Matcha: Magical drink or much ado about nothing?

Not all brews are the same, experts say

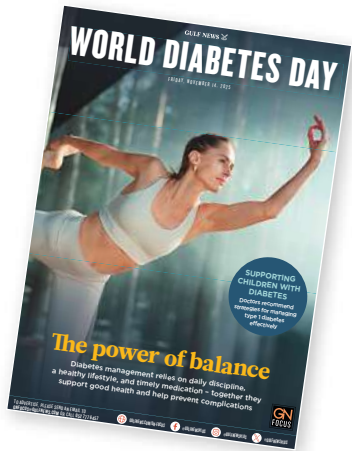
DUBAI
BY KARISHMA NANDKEOLYAR
Assistant Online Editor

Entire cafes have been dedicated to it, social media influencers have used the name for their handles, and in Japan there's even a city, Uji, dedicated to crafting all things matcha. But is this anti-oxidant rich superdrink really all it's cracked up to be or is it a passing fad? The first thing you need to know about this green gold is that it does actually have caffeine — less than coffee, more than other green teas. Which means, pregnant women and those sensitive to caffeine should be careful about how much they drink in a day. The second is it can be an acquired taste — people who may not love it at first



gulp could find themselves looking forward to the brew given some time. "When I was 20, I was in Japan for an exchange programme," recalls Dubai-based Filipino-Chinese expat Shanna Uy. "I couldn't understand what all the fuss was about. When I returned to Tokyo at 28, my friends convinced me to give it another shot, and surprisingly, I actually enjoyed it." And the third is, all matcha is not made the same. The quality of your matcha will define several things: price, taste, texture, and effect.

SEE ALSO P4



SPECIAL REPORT

Find balance with simple habits that keep diabetes in check



FRIDAY

Step into the cool season with fresh style and outdoor energy

Subscribe in print and online
www.store.gulfnews.com
www.gulfnews.com/subscriptions
Tel: 600 587 234
E mail: circ@gulfnews.com

PRICE UAE: Dh 5.00	Bahrain: BD 0.500 Oman: RO 0.500 India: Rs 40.00	S.Arabia: SR 5.00 Pakistan: Rs 100.00
--------------------	--	--

UAE to shorten credit recovery time to 6 months

CURRENTLY, DEFAULTERS NEED TO REBUILD FOR AS LONG AS 24 MONTHS

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

The UAE is poised to overhaul its credit-scoring system, radically shortening the time individuals spend in the so-called "red zone." Currently, the Etihad Credit Bureau (ECB) allows defaulters to rebuild for as long as 24 months before their score recovers. With the new Version 3 model, that period could drop to just six months, depending on improved payment behaviour. Beyond faster recovery, the ECB will open its scoring to a broader group of consumers — those with little or no traditional bank borrowing. The refreshed algorithm will incorporate rental payments, utilities, telecom bills and other "alternative" data to establish credit-profiles for newcomers to the market.

Greater flexibility

Marwan Ahmad Lutfi, Director General of the ECB, says the shift reflects a belief that "penalising someone for years is not how you improve financial behaviour." The bureau has built the new model in-house for greater flexibility, allowing algorithm updates quarterly to reflect local economic and consumer trends. For borrowers, the implications are significant: a clearer path back to creditworthiness and a recognition of improved conduct could unlock credit lines sooner than before. For lenders, the more dynamic system promises more timely insights on risk and behaviour. Analysts say the move strengthens

CREDIT CHECK TOOL

- The Etihad Credit Bureau is launching a new peer-to-peer credit-check tool via UAE Pass.
- For Dh80, property owners or service providers can access a potential tenant's credit score — but only with their consent through UAE Pass.
- The system aims to cut out delays and false assurances in rentals, short-term leases, and private deals.
- This marks the first time consent-based credit info sharing is embedded in UAE Pass, with wider use cases set for next year.

— N.D.

the UAE's push toward a more inclusive financial ecosystem. The new system is currently undergoing testing and is expected to roll out before mid-2026 in collaboration with the Central Bank of the UAE and local lenders. Once live, it will mark arguably the most comprehensive upgrade to the UAE credit-scoring framework since the bureau's inception. The ECB is also working on parallel tools designed to give consumers more transparency, including clearer explanations of score changes and simplified access to reports. Officials say these additions will help residents understand how their day-to-day financial decisions influence long-term credit health, supporting a wider shift toward responsible borrowing across the country.

SEE ALSO P6



WORLD 14 NOV DIABETES DAY FREE HEALTH SCREENING

Are you concerned about your risk of diabetes?

Visit our kiosks at select malls and community centres across the UAE for screenings. No appointments are necessary.

Remember, screening can help prevent diabetes or detect it early when it can be better treated.

Scan for more details.



www.nmc.ae

